# Continental Drift

Continent=One of the Large landmasses on the Earth.  E.g. Africa

Continental drift=the Earths continents are moving.

Wegener first suggested this.

He based his ideas on the following.

1. The continents fit together like parts of a jigsaw puzzle, so perhaps they were once joined.
2. Fossils of long dead animals were found on continents that are far apart.

Later evidence.

1. Ocean ridges and rifts suggest that the seafloor may be spreading in some places(ridges) and sinking in other places(trenches)
2. Magnetic striping.  Symmetrical magnetic  patterns form along the ocean ridges
3. Sediment thickness.  As you move away from an ocean ridge the sedimentary rock layers become thicker, suggesting that they are older.  So the ridges show new rock forming.

So what does the theory of plate tectonics suggest?

Plate tectonics= the Earth's surface is broken into a number of shifting plates

## Key Words

| Word | Meaning |
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| Continent | |
| Ocean ridge | |
| Ocean trench | |
| Subduction | |
| Sediment | Matter that settles to the bottom of a river, ocean or lake. |
| Sedimentary rock | Rock that has formed through sediment falling to the bottom of an ocean or lake or sea. The sediment builds up in layers and turns to solid rock over time. |